Chapter Twenty-Six

Westward

Around 1200,
a Mayan empire grows in Central America,
and the Inca slaughter the villagers of the Cuzco valley

ACROSS THE ATLANTIC, two new stories were unfolding.

On the Central American land bridge, the city of Chichen Itza, ruled by Toltec invaders, was itself facing invasion.* Its king carried out bloody rituals of human sacrifice, pouring out the sacred earth-restoring liquid in an attempt to keep his kingdom safe. But the sacrifices failed him. Sometime around the turn of the century, the Mayan king Hunac Ceel launched an attack against Chichen Itza's imposing walls. To carry out his assault on his huge neighbor, he had hired seven generals and their troops from the fragmented lands farther to the southeast.

With the help of these mercenaries, he captured Chichen Itza; the city fell, a slightly later chronicle tells us, "because of the treachery of Hunac Ceel," which suggests that the conquest may have come about through trickery and betrayal, rather than simply through force of arms. However it began, the invasion ended with Chichen Itza sacked and burned, its sacred reliefs shattered and defaced, the places of offerings laid waste; the people fled outwards and took refuge in other cities.[1]